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New lessons:
Government teachers should use dialogue to help students see things from multiple perspectives

Spectrum of Hope

INDIA WILL BE ON A THRESHOLD OF TRANSFORMATION THE DAY GOVERNMENT SCHOOLS ARE ABLE TO ATTRACT CHILDREN FROM ACROSS THE SOCIAL SPECTRUM.

that traditional rural lifestyles generate lesser waste than the urban bourgeoisie. The teacher told me that he planned to extend the discussion to questions such as: What is development? How is humanity harming the earth? And, finally moving to the need for water harvesting, renewable energy, natural farming, and other sustainable practices.

As children explore issues through such real projects, the teacher should use dialogue to help them see things from multiple perspectives, thereby helping the child to develop a worldview that is broader than that of the community she lives in. As the complexity of projects, breadth of perspective and depth of dialogue increase through the school years, children will acquire a greater empathy towards their peers and the world they live in, and will also feel more confident about their own place in society.

This kind of educative process will create a critical and caring citizenry who will expand our notions of who we are, what society

should be, what development is, and how to live in harmony with each other and with nature. These children, our torchbearers, will help us find a more nuanced expression of our ideals, and also inclusive and practical ways to confront the challenges India faces today.

It is important to see that these are not esoteric and distant ideals, but very real possibilities. It might be counter-intuitive, but I believe that such ideals are easier to realise in the government school classrooms than in the more popular private schools.

My dream is to improve the quality of our government schools to such an extent that, no matter who we are, each one of us desires to educate our children here. The day when the local government school is able to attract children from across the social spectrum, that will be the day we can proudly proclaim that India is on the threshold of transformation.

The author is the chairman of Wipro Technologies.